

CS560 - UI/UX Design & Implementation

10-1 Journal: UI/UX Learning Reflection

Malgorzata Debska

Southern New Hampshire University

Nathan Palmer

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UI/UX Design and Implementation Reflection Journal

Throughout this UI/UX Design and Implementation course, I gained a much deeper understanding of what it takes to create digital products that are both functional and user-friendly. While I had previous experience with software development, this course helped me recognize that successful applications are built around the needs and expectations of users. Research shows that user-centered design leads to products that are more effective, efficient, and satisfying to use (Norman, 2013). Looking back, I can clearly see how much my perspective and skills have grown.

The most challenging aspect of the coursework was learning how to evaluate an interface from the user's point of view instead of focusing only on technical functionality. In several assignments, I had to conduct usability evaluations, identify workflow inefficiencies, and justify design recommendations using established UX principles. At first, it was difficult to step outside my developer mindset and think like an end user. I overcame this challenge by studying usability heuristics, reviewing examples of effective interface design, and practicing with real-world applications. Over time, I became more confident in recognizing design issues and proposing meaningful improvements based on evidence rather than assumptions.

My approach to UI/UX design and implementation has changed significantly since the beginning of the course. Initially, I believed that a clean interface and working features were enough to create a successful application. I now understand that good design requires user research, accessibility, iterative testing, and continuous improvement. Nielsen (2020) emphasizes that usability depends on how easily users can accomplish their goals while minimizing confusion

and errors. As a result, I have learned to prioritize user needs early in the design process and create workflows that are intuitive and inclusive for different audiences.

One assignment that had the greatest impact on my growth was the usability evaluation case study, where I analyzed an existing public-facing application and developed recommendations for improving its user experience. This project was meaningful because it required me to combine heuristic evaluation, workflow analysis, accessibility principles, and evidence-based reasoning into a comprehensive assessment. Rather than simply identifying flaws, I had to explain why those issues affected users and recommend practical solutions. This experience strengthened my critical thinking skills and reinforced the importance of making design decisions based on established usability principles and user-centered methodologies.

The knowledge I gained from this course will be valuable in both my academic and professional career. As I continue pursuing opportunities in software engineering and developing applications, I plan to integrate UI/UX best practices into every stage of the software development lifecycle. This is particularly important for projects designed to support vulnerable populations, where accessibility, clarity, and ease of use can directly influence outcomes. I also expect these skills to improve my collaboration with designers, developers, and stakeholders while creating products that better meet user needs.

My greatest strengths in UI/UX design are my attention to detail, analytical thinking, and willingness to learn from user feedback. I enjoy identifying opportunities to simplify workflows and improve usability through thoughtful design. At the same time, I recognize that I still have room to grow in conducting large-scale user research and analyzing data from usability testing sessions. Continuing to build these skills will help me become a more effective and well-rounded UI/UX practitioner.

This course has fundamentally changed the way I think about software development by emphasizing that technology should always be designed with the user in mind. I leave the course with greater confidence in my ability to evaluate interfaces, recommend meaningful improvements, and contribute to creating applications that are accessible, efficient, and engaging.

No AI tools are used.

References:

Nielsen, J. (2020). *Usability 101: Introduction to usability*. Nielsen Norman Group.
<https://www.nngroup.com/articles/usability-101-introduction-to-usability/>

Norman, D. A. (2013). *The design of everyday things* (Revised and expanded ed.)